FREE SAMPLE · CHAPTERS 1-3

THE PHOTO RESET

Better photos with the phone you already have.



About This Sample

This is a free extract from **The Photo Reset**, a step-by-step system for taking better photos with the phone you already have.

The three chapters here are the ones that change the most for the least effort: why your photos look flat, how to find and use light, and how to decide what goes in the frame. Fix those three and the rest is detail.

CHAPTER 1

Why Your Photos Look Flat

You saw something beautiful. You took the photo. The photo is... fine. Disappointing, even. That gap is the whole problem this guide solves, and it has almost nothing to do with your phone being a cheap one.

What your eyes do that your phone can't

Your eyes see far more light range than any camera. Standing in a room, you can see detail in a bright window and in a dark corner at the same time. Your phone has to choose. That's why the window turns into a white blur or the room turns black.

Your eyes ignore clutter. Looking at a friend, your brain crops out the bin behind them, the pole growing out of their head and the stranger in a yellow coat. The camera keeps all of it.

Your brain adds the moment. You remember the smell of the food, the sound of the waves, the fact that it was your daughter's first steps. The photo only has what's inside the frame.

So good photography is mostly about **giving the camera a scene it can handle**, and **removing everything that doesn't belong**.

The four things that actually matter

In order of how much they change your photos:

1. Light. Where it comes from, how hard it is, what colour it is. (Chapter 2)

2. What's in the frame, and what isn't. Composition and backgrounds. (Chapter 3)

3. Distance and angle. Most photos are taken from standing height, from too far away. Moving two steps closer or crouching down transforms a photo, and costs nothing. (Chapter 3)

4. Timing. Waiting two seconds for the person to laugh, the wave to break, the car to leave the frame.

Settings and editing matter too, and they're in Chapters 4 and 9. But they polish a photo. They don't rescue one taken in bad light, from a bad angle, with a bin in the background.

"I need a better phone"

Almost never true. A recent phone helps in low light and gives you a longer lens, but the difference between a mediocre photo and a great one is almost always the person holding it.

Try this test: look at a photo you love from a professional and ask what's actually different. Nine times out of ten it's the light, the background and the distance, not the camera.

The mindset shift

Beginners point the phone at a **thing**. Better photographers arrange a **picture**: they decide where the light is coming from, what's behind the subject, how close they are, and when to press the button.

That takes about ten extra seconds. It's the whole difference.

> **The rule for this guide:** before every photo, spend ten seconds on light, background and distance.

CHAPTER 2

Light: The One That Matters Most

If you only change one thing after reading this guide, change where you stand relative to the light.

The three questions

1. Where is the light coming from? Behind you, behind your subject, from the side, from above?

2. How hard is it? Hard light comes from a small or distant source (direct sun, a bare bulb, your phone's flash) and makes sharp-edged, dark shadows. Soft light comes from a large source (an overcast sky, a big window, light bouncing off a wall) and makes gentle shadows.

3. What colour is it? Household bulbs are orange. Shade is blue. Fluorescent and LED lights can be green. Mixing them is what makes skin look strange.

Soft light is the easy win

Soft light flatters almost everything: faces, food, objects, flowers.

Where to find it:

- **A window, out of direct sun.** The biggest soft light source in most homes.
- **An overcast day.** The whole sky becomes one giant softbox. Cloudy days are a gift, not a problem.
- **Open shade:** the shadow side of a building, under a tree with a clear view of open sky.
- **Indoors near a doorway** with daylight coming in.

The simplest trick in this guide: put your subject near a window, turn off the room lights, and take the photo with the window to one side of them. That one move makes portraits, food and product photos look instantly better.

Direction changes everything

Light direction	What it does
From behind you (front light)	Even and safe, but flat. Fine for record shots, boring for good ones
From the side	Shows shape and texture. The most useful direction for faces, food and objects
From behind the subject (backlight)	Glowing edges, bright backgrounds, moody silhouettes. Hardest to expose, most rewarding

Light direction	What it does
From above	Natural outdoors at midday, but makes dark eye sockets on faces. Move to shade

Hard light: use it on purpose or avoid it

Direct midday sun is the hardest light most of us encounter. It makes harsh shadows, blown-out highlights and squinting faces.

To avoid it: move your subject into open shade, or wait.

To use it on purpose: look for strong shapes, long shadows, patterns and contrast. Hard light makes dramatic photos of buildings, streets and objects. It rarely flatters faces.

Golden hour and blue hour

Golden hour is roughly the hour after sunrise and the hour before sunset. The sun is low, so the light is softer, warmer and comes from the side. It's the easiest beautiful light there is.

Blue hour is the twenty to forty minutes after sunset and before sunrise. The sky is deep blue, city lights are on, and both are bright enough to appear in the same photo. It's the best time for city and skyline photos.

Practical advice: if you're planning a photo of a place or a person, plan it for golden hour. The same scene photographed at 1pm and at 7pm looks like two different places.

Backlight without ruining the photo

Backlight is when the main light is behind your subject: a window behind someone's head, the sun behind a tree.

Phones usually expose for the bright background, so your subject goes dark. Three fixes:

1. **Tap the subject on screen** so the phone exposes for them, then drag the brightness slider if it's still too dark. (Chapter 4)
2. **Move so something bright faces your subject:** a white wall, a pale pavement, a sunlit building across the street. That bounced light fills their face.
3. **Commit to a silhouette.** Expose for the bright background, let your subject go black, and make sure the shape is clean and recognisable.

Indoor light at night

Household light is dim, orange and comes from above. Three ways to improve it:

- **Get closer to the light source,** or bring your subject closer to a lamp.
- **Turn off mixed lighting.** If you have a warm lamp and a cool ceiling light on at once, pick one. Mixed colours are the main reason indoor photos look odd.

- **Avoid the built-in flash** for people. It's a tiny, hard light pointed straight at the subject: flat faces, harsh shadows behind, red or glassy eyes. Chapter 8 covers better options.

A small habit that pays off

Whenever you arrive anywhere you might take photos, ask yourself one question: **where is the good light?** Then put the subject in it. That habit alone separates people whose photos look nice from people whose photos look like snapshots.

CHAPTER 3

Composition: What's In The Frame

Composition sounds artistic. In practice it's three decisions: where to stand, what to include, and what to leave out.

Start with the background

The background ruins more photos than any other single thing. Before you press the button, look past your subject:

- Bins, cables, signs, parked cars
- A pole, tree or lamp "growing" out of someone's head
- Bright patches that pull the eye away
- A sloping horizon
- Random strangers walking through

The fix takes two seconds: move one step left or right, crouch down so the background becomes sky or a clean wall, or ask your subject to turn around so the clutter is behind you instead of behind them.

Get closer

Most beginner photos include far too much. The subject is a small element in a wide scene, so nothing in the photo feels important.

- **Walk closer.** Don't zoom: zooming on most phones crops the image and loses quality (Chapter 4).
- **Fill the frame** with what the photo is actually about.
- **Ask: what is this photo of?** If you can't answer in three words, you're too far away.

Change your height

Almost everyone photographs from standing height, which is why most photos look the same.

- **Crouch or kneel** for children, pets and flowers, so you're at their eye level instead of looking down at the top of their head.
- **Get low** to make a subject look bigger, and to turn a messy background into clean sky.
- **Get high** (stand on a step, hold the phone above your head) for crowds, flat-lays and street scenes.

The rule of thirds, and when to ignore it

Turn on your camera's grid (Chapter 4). It divides the frame into nine boxes.

- **Place your subject on one of the lines or crossing points** rather than dead centre. It usually feels more natural and leaves room for the subject to look or move into.
- **Put the horizon on a line,** not through the middle. More sky for a dramatic sky, more ground for an interesting foreground.

When to ignore it: symmetrical scenes (a corridor, a reflection, a face straight on) look better dead centre. Rules of composition are defaults, not laws.

Lines, frames and layers

- **Leading lines:** roads, fences, rivers, shadows and railings pull the eye toward your subject. Stand so they point at it.
- **Natural frames:** doorways, windows, arches and overhanging branches put a border around your subject and add depth.
- **Layers:** include something in the foreground (a branch, a railing, a shoulder) so the photo feels three-dimensional rather than flat.
- **Negative space:** a large area of empty sky, wall or water around a small subject creates calm and makes the subject stronger.

Straighten up

Sloping horizons and leaning buildings make a photo look careless. Use the grid to line up horizontals and verticals when you shoot, and straighten in editing if you miss (Chapter 9).

Timing is part of composition

The frame changes second by second. Wait for:

- the person to look up or laugh instead of posing stiffly
- the cyclist to enter the empty part of the frame
- the group of strangers to walk out of it
- the wave, the steam, the bird

Take more than one. Professionals take many frames of the same scene and keep one. Burst mode (Chapter 5) exists for exactly this.

The ten-second routine

Before you press the button:

1. **Light:** where is it coming from? Should I move?
2. **Background:** is anything distracting behind my subject?

3. **Distance:** can I get closer?
4. **Height:** would this look better from lower or higher?
5. **Straight:** is the horizon level?

Ten seconds, five questions. This is the whole chapter, and it's on the printable **Pre-Shot Card (Appendix A)**.

What's In The Full Guide

This sample covered the first three chapters. The complete guide continues with:

- **Your phone's camera settings**: the eight that matter, and which lens to use when
- **Getting sharp photos**: the four causes of blur and the fix for each
- **Photographing people**: distance, light, posing people who hate posing, groups, children and pets
- **The subjects you actually photograph**: food, pets, landscapes, cities, flowers and things you're selling
- **Night and low light**: night mode, finding light that already exists, silhouettes and light trails
- **Editing**: a ten-minute routine in eight steps, and the things that make an edit look amateur
- **The diagnostic**: find the symptom, apply the fix
- **The ten most common mistakes**
- **Organising and backing up**, so you don't lose any of it
- **A 30-day photo reset**: one idea a week, a short exercise a day

Printable extras: a pocket pre-shot card, a 30-day practice log, a one-page diagnostic cheat sheet and an editing recipe.